
WordPress Performance Incident Runbook

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Dan Knauss, General Editor

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Use this runbook when a WordPress site has an active or suspected performance incident: elevated TTFB, low cache hit ratio, PHP worker saturation, database slowdown, object-cache failure, WP-Cron or Action Scheduler backlog, external API latency, or a Core Web Vitals regression that is materially affecting users.

This is an execution document. It intentionally differs from the broader guides:

- [wordpress-performance-optimization-checklist.md](#) explains the general diagnostic flow and transport-layer signal-following discipline.
- [enterprise-performance-operational-checklist.md](#) expands the same discipline for high-traffic and platform-governed environments.
- [DEVELOPER_REFERENCE.md](#) explains the underlying APIs, cache layers, and performance model.
- [REFERENCE-WP-Transients-Persistent-Object-Cache.md](#) explains transients, persistent object cache behavior, and cache-stampede risk.

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Environment placeholders

Customize these before running commands:

```
export WP_PATH="[CUSTOMIZE: /path/to/wordpress]"
export SITE_URL="[CUSTOMIZE: https://example.com]"
export TARGET_URL="[CUSTOMIZE: https://example.com/problem-url/]"
export INCIDENT_ID="[CUSTOMIZE: YYYYMMDD-short-name]"
export OPTIONS_TABLE="[CUSTOMIZE: wp_options or wp_2_options]"
```

Assumptions:

- WP-CLI is available as wp.
- Commands run with a user that can read the WordPress install and, where needed, query the database.

- Production write operations require explicit incident lead approval.
- Multisite incidents must add `--url="$SITE_URL"` to site-specific WP-CLI commands.
- `OPTIONS_TABLE` must match the affected site table prefix. For multisite, use the affected blog options table such as `wp_2_options`, not always `wp_options`.

Severity triggers

Severity	Trigger examples	Response expectation
SEV1	Public site broadly unavailable, checkout/account impossible, sustained origin overload, database unavailable	Immediate incident response, platform/hosting escalation, change freeze
SEV2	Major template or admin workflow slow for many users, cache hit ratio collapse, PHP workers saturated	Incident response with focused mitigation and stakeholder updates
SEV3	Degraded subset of URLs, single integration slow, Core Web Vitals regression without outage	Triage, measured fix, normal change controls unless risk grows

Safety rules

- Start read-only. Capture headers, timings, logs, and queue state before changing anything.
- Do not globally flush CDN/page/object caches unless the incident lead approves and the blast radius is understood.
- Do not disable plugins, change PHP versions, alter database indexes, or purge queues in production without rollback and approval.
- Do not cache authenticated, personalized, cart/checkout, preview, or admin responses as public HTML.
- Prefer bypassing, isolating, or rate-limiting one bad path over broad site-wide changes.

- Preserve evidence: save command output, timestamps, and before/after measurements.

First 10 minutes

1. Assign roles: incident lead, WordPress engineer, platform/hosting engineer, communications owner.
 2. Confirm user impact and severity.
 3. Freeze unrelated deploys, cache-rule changes, and plugin/theme updates.
 4. Capture response headers and timings for one affected URL and one known-good URL.
 5. Determine whether the affected request is served from edge/page cache or reaches origin/PHP.
 6. Pick the matching procedure below and proceed.
-

Procedure 1: Initial performance incident triage

Procedure Metadata

- Owner: [CUSTOMIZE: Incident lead]
- Last Tested: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD]
- Review Cadence: Quarterly
- Last Drill Date: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD / N/A]

Purpose

Establish the incident scope, preserve evidence, and decide which deeper procedure to run next.

Prerequisites

- Shell access with `curl`.
- WP-CLI access for the target WordPress install.
- Known affected URL and expected user state: anonymous, logged-in, admin, REST, AJAX, cron, or checkout/account.

Commands

```
date -u
printf 'Incident: %s\nSite: %s\nTarget: %s\n' "$INCIDENT_ID" "$SITE_URL" "$TARGET_URL"

curl -sS -o /dev/null -D "headers-${INCIDENT_ID}.txt" \
  -w 'dns:%{time_namelookup} connect:%{time_connect} tls:%{time_appconnect} ttfb:%{time_total}' \
  "$TARGET_URL"

sed -n '1,80p' "headers-${INCIDENT_ID}.txt"

wp --path="$WP_PATH" core version
wp --path="$WP_PATH" option get siteurl
wp --path="$WP_PATH" option get home
```

Expected Output

- curl reports HTTP status, TTFB, and total time.
- Response headers show whether the response was a cache HIT, MISS, BYPASS, DYNAMIC, or origin response according to the site/CDN conventions.
- WP-CLI returns the WordPress version and expected site URLs.

Rollback

No rollback is required. This procedure is read-only.

Verification

```
test -s "headers-${INCIDENT_ID}.txt" && echo "headers captured"
wp --path="$WP_PATH" core is-installed && echo "wp-cli can inspect the install"
```

Expected: both checks print success messages.

Escalate If

- WP-CLI cannot access the install during a production incident.
- The site returns 5xx, connection failures, or TLS errors for broad public traffic.
- Headers indicate private/authenticated content may be cached publicly.

Procedure 2: High TTFB on anonymous public pages

Procedure Metadata

- Owner: [CUSTOMIZE: WordPress engineer]
- Last Tested: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD]
- Review Cadence: Quarterly
- Last Drill Date: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD / N/A]

Purpose

Determine whether high anonymous-page TTFB is caused by cache miss/bypass, transport/edge delay, origin/PHP execution, database work, object-cache misses, or external dependencies.

Prerequisites

- Affected URL is safe to request anonymously.
- CDN/page-cache header conventions are known.
- Permission to inspect cache rules and origin metrics.

Commands

```
for i in 1 2 3; do
  curl -sS -o /dev/null -D "headers-${INCIDENT_ID}-anon-${i}.txt" \
    -w "run:${i} dns:%{time_namelookup} connect:%{time_connect} tls:%{time_appconnect} \
      "$TARGET_URL"
done
```

```
grep -E '^(HTTP/|cache-control:|Cache-Control:|age:|Age:|x-cache|X-Cache|cf-cache-status|CF-Cache-Status|x-redirect-by|X-Redirect-By|set-cookie:|Set-Cookie:)' headers-${INCIDENT_ID}-anon-*.txt || true
```

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" cron event list --due-now
```

```
# Optional write operation - run only after incident lead approval.
# This can add database load and remove evidence of transient churn.
# wp --path="$WP_PATH" transient delete --expired
```


Expected Output

- Repeated anonymous requests should show whether TTFB improves after warming.
- Cache headers should explain HIT, MISS, BYPASS, DYNAMIC, or equivalent behavior.
- Set-Cookie on anonymous cacheable pages is a red flag because it can fragment or bypass HTML cache.

Rollback

No rollback is required for the default read-only checks. If the optional expired-transient cleanup is approved and run, there is no practical rollback for deleted expired transient rows; rely on application regeneration and continue monitoring. If an approved cache-rule change is made outside this procedure, restore the previous cache rule from the CDN/host change history.

Verification

```
curl -sS -o /dev/null -D "headers-#{INCIDENT_ID}-verify.txt" \
  -w 'ttfb:#{time_starttransfer} total:#{time_total} code:#{http_code}\n' \
  "$TARGET_URL"
```

```
grep -E '^(HTTP/|age:|Age:|x-cache|X-Cache|cf-cache-status|CF-Cache-Status|cache-control:|Cache-Control:)' "headers-#{INCIDENT_ID}-verify.txt" || true
```

Expected: cacheable anonymous pages show an intentional cache status and improved TTFB after warming.

Escalate If

- Cacheable anonymous pages consistently bypass cache without an intentional reason.
 - Cache headers vary by marketing query strings, unnecessary cookies, or inconsistent device/geo keys.
 - Origin TTFB remains high after confirming cache hit behavior.
 - A cache purge or rule change is needed during peak traffic.
-

Procedure 3: High TTFB on logged-in, admin, REST, or AJAX requests

Procedure Metadata

- Owner: [CUSTOMIZE: WordPress engineer]
- Last Tested: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD]
- Review Cadence: Quarterly
- Last Drill Date: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD / N/A]

Purpose

Diagnose slow dynamic requests that cannot be solved by public full-page caching.

Prerequisites

- A target URL, REST route, AJAX action, or admin screen has been identified.
- Authentication method is available for deeper tooling if needed.
- WP-CLI profile and doctor packages may not be installed; check availability before relying on them.

Commands

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" cli has-command profile && echo "profile available" || echo "profile not available"
wp --path="$WP_PATH" cli has-command doctor && echo "doctor available" || echo "doctor not available"
```

```
# If profile is available:
```

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" profile stage --url="$TARGET_URL" || true
```

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" profile hook --url="$TARGET_URL" --all || true
```

```
# If doctor is available:
```

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" doctor check || true
```

```
# Always safe baseline checks:
```

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" plugin list --status=active
```

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" theme list --status=active
```

Expected Output

- `wp profile stage` identifies whether bootstrap, main query, template, or shutdown dominates.

- `wp profile` hook identifies slow hooks/callbacks.
- `wp doctor` check flags common foot-guns where available.
- Active plugin/theme inventory supports rollback and ownership decisions.

Rollback

No rollback is required for profiling. If an approved mitigation disables a plugin/module or changes configuration, restore the previous plugin/configuration state from the incident log or deployment system.

Verification

```
curl -sS -o /dev/null -D "headers-`${INCIDENT_ID}-dynamic-verify.txt" \
-w 'ttfb: `${time_start}transfer} total: `${time_total} code: `${http_code}\\n' \
"$TARGET_URL"
```

Expected: TTFB and total time improve for the same authenticated/dynamic path, or the dominant bottleneck is identified for escalation.

Escalate If

- Profiling points to a third-party plugin, theme, or external API without a safe local mitigation.
- PHP workers are saturated or requests queue at the host level.
- Admin/editor workflows are blocked for publishing, ecommerce, membership, or support teams.
- WordPress 7.0 admin/editor compatibility issues are suspected after an upgrade.

Procedure 4: Database slowdown, autoload bloat, or expensive queries

Procedure Metadata

- Owner: [CUSTOMIZE: WordPress/database engineer]
- Last Tested: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD]
- Review Cadence: Quarterly
- Last Drill Date: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD / N/A]

Purpose

Identify whether database time is dominated by slow queries, too many queries, inefficient query shape, or autoloaded option bloat.

Prerequisites

- Database read access through WP-CLI.
- Approval before changing options, deleting data, or adding indexes.
- Current backup/snapshot before any write operation.

Commands

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" db query "SELECT option_name, LENGTH(option_value) AS size, autoload FROM wp_options ORDER BY size DESC LIMIT 20;"
```

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" db query "SELECT SUM(LENGTH(option_value)) AS autoload_bytes FROM wp_options;"
```

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" db size --tables
```

Expected Output

- Autoload queries include both legacy yes and modern WordPress 6.6+ values: on, auto, and auto-on.
- Large autoloaded options are identified by name and size.
- Large tables are identified for deeper query review.

Rollback

If an approved autoload change is made, record the previous autoload value first and restore it if behavior regresses.

```
# Read before changing.
```

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" db query "SELECT option_name, autoload FROM ${OPTIONS_TABLE} WHERE option_name = '[CUSTOMIZE: option_name]'"
```

```
# Rollback example - choose the previous value captured above.
```

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" option set-autoload "[CUSTOMIZE: option_name]" on
```

Verification

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" db query "SELECT SUM(LENGTH(option_value)) AS autoload_bytes FROM wp_options WHERE autoload='yes';"
```

```
curl -sS -o /dev/null -D "headers-{$INCIDENT_ID}-db-verify.txt" \
-w 'tftb:#{time_start}ttransfer} total:#{time_total} code:#{http_code}\n' \
"$TARGET_URL"
```

Expected: autoload footprint decreases if that was the target, and the affected request improves without functional regression.

Escalate If

- Database CPU, I/O, or lock waits are elevated at the host/provider level.
- Slow queries require schema/index changes in production.
- A large option is owned by a plugin/theme and changing autoload state could affect correctness.
- Queries use broad post meta, taxonomy exclusions, LIKE, or unbounded result sets at production scale.

Procedure 5: Object cache failure or cache stampede

Procedure Metadata

- Owner: [CUSTOMIZE: WordPress/platform engineer]
- Last Tested: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD]
- Review Cadence: Quarterly
- Last Drill Date: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD / N/A]

Purpose

Determine whether a persistent object cache failure, poor hit rate, key misuse, or cache stampede is causing origin/database overload.

Prerequisites

- Access to WordPress filesystem and cache service metrics.
- Knowledge of whether Redis, Memcached, Object Cache Pro, or another drop-in is used.
- Approval before restarting cache services or flushing object cache.

Commands

```
test -f "$WP_PATH/wp-content/object-cache.php" && echo "object-cache.php drop-in present" || echo "no persistent object-cache drop-in found"
```

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" cache type || true  
wp --path="$WP_PATH" cache get non_existing_key incident_probe || true
```

```
# Optional write operation - run only after incident lead approval.  
# This can add database load and remove evidence of transient churn.  
# wp --path="$WP_PATH" transient delete --expired
```

Expected Output

- `object-cache.php` presence confirms a persistent object-cache drop-in is installed, but service metrics must confirm health.
- Cache command behavior identifies whether WP-CLI can interact with the configured object cache.
- Expired transient cleanup is intentionally not part of the default read-only evidence gathering. If approved, it is only a cleanup action and should not be treated as a primary incident fix.

Rollback

Do not flush object cache as rollback. If optional expired-transient cleanup is approved and run, there is no practical rollback for deleted expired transient rows; rely on application regeneration and continue monitoring. If an approved cache-service restart or configuration change worsens the incident, restore the previous service/configuration state through the hosting/platform control plane.

```
# Plugin-dependent - uncomment the cache plugin(s) in use only after approval:  
# wp --path="$WP_PATH" redis status
```

```
# wp --path="$WP_PATH" redis enable
# wp --path="$WP_PATH" redis disable
```

Verification

```
curl -sS -o /dev/null -D "headers-{$INCIDENT_ID}-cache-verify.txt" \
-w 'tftb:{$time_startttransfer} total:{$time_total} code:{$http_code}\n' \
"$TARGET_URL"
```

Expected: database load, cache errors, or TTFB improve after the approved mitigation.

Escalate If

- Cache service is unreachable, evicting heavily, or out of memory.
 - alloptions or transient stampedes are suspected under concurrent traffic.
 - Code relies on wp_cache_add () locks without a shared persistent object cache with atomic add semantics.
 - A global object-cache flush is proposed during high traffic.
-

Procedure 6: WP-Cron or Action Scheduler backlog

Procedure Metadata

- Owner: [CUSTOMIZE: WordPress operations engineer]
- Last Tested: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD]
- Review Cadence: Quarterly
- Last Drill Date: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD / N/A]

Purpose

Identify whether due cron events, failed scheduled actions, or overlapping background jobs are causing request-time latency or delayed business workflows.

Prerequisites

- WP-CLI access.
- Approval before disabling WP-Cron, changing schedules, or canceling/deleting jobs.
- Knowledge of whether WooCommerce or Action Scheduler is active.

Commands

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" cron event list --due-now
wp --path="$WP_PATH" cron event list --fields=hook,next_run_relative,recurrence

# Plugin-dependent - uncomment if Action Scheduler WP-CLI commands are available:
# wp --path="$WP_PATH" action-scheduler list --status=pending --per-page=20
# wp --path="$WP_PATH" action-scheduler list --status=failed --per-page=20
```

Expected Output

- Due cron events should clear when the runner works.
- Repeated due events, long-running hooks, or growing queues indicate a backlog.
- Failed Action Scheduler jobs identify plugin/business workflow ownership.

Rollback

If `DISABLE_WP_CRON` was added and the external runner is not working, remove or comment out the constant and clear OPcache if required by the host.

```
// Rollback in wp-config.php if the external runner fails:
// define( 'DISABLE_WP_CRON', true );
```

Verification

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" cron event list --due-now

# If using a system runner, verify it can run due events:
wp --path="$WP_PATH" cron event run --due-now --quiet
wp --path="$WP_PATH" cron event list --due-now
```

Expected: due events decrease or clear; business workflows such as scheduled posts, cleanup jobs, and ecommerce queues resume.

Escalate If

- The queue grows after the runner is confirmed.
- Jobs fail repeatedly for the same hook or plugin owner.

- Running due events causes PHP/database saturation.
 - A high-traffic site still relies only on request-triggered WP-Cron.
-

Procedure 7: External API, AI connector, or third-party latency

Procedure Metadata

- Owner: [CUSTOMIZE: WordPress engineer / integration owner]
- Last Tested: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD]
- Review Cadence: Quarterly
- Last Drill Date: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD / N/A]

Purpose

Identify whether external HTTP calls, WordPress 7.0 AI/connectors integrations, payment/search/CRM APIs, analytics, or embed providers are slowing critical requests.

Prerequisites

- Affected request path is known.
- Integration owners and API status pages are known.
- A safe fallback or feature flag is identified before disabling integrations.

Commands

```
wp --path="$WP_PATH" plugin list --status=active --fields=name,status,version,update
```

```
curl -sS -o /dev/null -D "headers-${INCIDENT_ID}-external.txt" \
-w 'ttfb:%{time_starttransfer} total:%{time_total} code:%{http_code}\n' \
"$TARGET_URL"
```

Expected Output

- Active plugin inventory identifies likely integration owners.
- Timings show whether the request is slow enough to justify deeper APM/Query Monitor inspection.
- APM traces, if available, should separate HTTP API time from PHP, database, and cache time.

Rollback

If an approved feature flag, connector setting, or plugin configuration change is made, restore the prior setting from the incident log or configuration management system.

```
# Plugin-dependent - uncomment only for the specific plugin/feature flag in use:
# wp --path="$WP_PATH" option get "[CUSTOMIZE: option_name]"
# wp --path="$WP_PATH" option update "[CUSTOMIZE: option_name]" "[CUSTOMIZE: previous_value]"
```

Verification

```
curl -sS -o /dev/null -D "headers-{$INCIDENT_ID}-external-verify.txt" \
-w 'ttfb:#{time_start}transfer:#{time_total} code:#{http_code}\n' \
"$TARGET_URL"
```

Expected: request time improves or APM confirms the external dependency is no longer in the critical path.

Escalate If

- The dependency is required for checkout, login, publishing, search, or compliance.
- Timeouts/retries amplify traffic or worker saturation.
- AI/connector workflows expose credential, privacy, or rate-limit risk.
- No safe degraded mode exists.

Procedure 8: Core Web Vitals regression

Procedure Metadata

- Owner: [CUSTOMIZE: Frontend/WordPress engineer]
- Last Tested: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD]
- Review Cadence: Quarterly
- Last Drill Date: [CUSTOMIZE: YYYY-MM-DD / N/A]

Purpose

Triage a user-facing LCP, INP, or CLS regression without confusing frontend symptoms with backend, cache, or transport causes.

Prerequisites

- Affected template or URL set is known.
- Field data source is identified: CrUX, RUM, Search Console, analytics, or APM browser agent.
- Browser tooling may be required for final diagnosis; if unavailable, capture backend/transport evidence first and escalate for browser inspection.

Commands

```
curl -sS -o /dev/null -D "headers-{$INCIDENT_ID}-cwv.txt" \
-w 'dns:%{time_namelookup} connect:%{time_connect} tls:%{time_appconnect} ttfb:%
"$TARGET_URL"
```

```
grep -E '^(HTTP/|cache-control:|Cache-Control:|age:|Age:|x-cache|X-
Cache|cf-cache-status|CF-Cache-Status|content-type:|Content-Type:)' "headers-
{$INCIDENT_ID}-cwv.txt" || true
```

Expected Output

- Transport and TTFB data clarify whether poor LCP may start with slow document delivery.
- Cache headers clarify whether public HTML and assets are delivered efficiently.
- Further LCP/INP/CLS diagnosis usually requires browser traces, RUM, or lab tooling.

Rollback

If the regression follows a deploy, rollback through the normal release system after incident lead approval. If it follows a CDN/cache/optimization plugin change, restore the previous configuration.

Verification

```
curl -sS -o /dev/null -D "headers-{$INCIDENT_ID}-cwv-verify.txt" \
-w 'ttfb:%{time_starttransfer} total:%{time_total} code:%{http_code}\n' \
"$TARGET_URL"
```

Expected: backend/transport signals are healthy before handing off to browser-level investigation; after frontend mitigation, field or lab metrics improve for the same template/device class.

Escalate If

- LCP remains poor despite fast cached TTFB.
 - INP regression correlates with third-party scripts, page-builder runtime, or new editor/frontend assets.
 - CLS is caused by ads, embeds, consent banners, notices, or late-injected personalized content.
 - Browser automation, DevTools traces, screenshots, or visual inspection are required and not available in the current session.
-

Recovery verification checklist

- ☐ Same URL, same user state, and same cache state were tested before and after mitigation.
- ☐ Public cache behavior is intentional and safe.
- ☐ Authenticated, personalized, checkout, account, admin, preview, and REST/AJAX paths still behave correctly.
- ☐ PHP errors, database errors, and cache-service errors are not increasing.
- ☐ Cron and queues are clearing if they were part of the incident.
- ☐ APM/RUM/headers/logs show recovery, not just one successful manual request.
- ☐ Stakeholders know what changed and what remains under watch.

Post-incident follow-up

- ☐ Write a short timeline with symptoms, trigger, detection, mitigation, and verification.
- ☐ Open follow-up issues for root-cause fixes that were not safe during the incident.
- ☐ Add or tune alerts for the earliest reliable signal.
- ☐ Review cache rules, object-cache health, slow queries, cron schedules, and external dependencies touched during the incident.
- ☐ Update this runbook if responders had to improvise.